

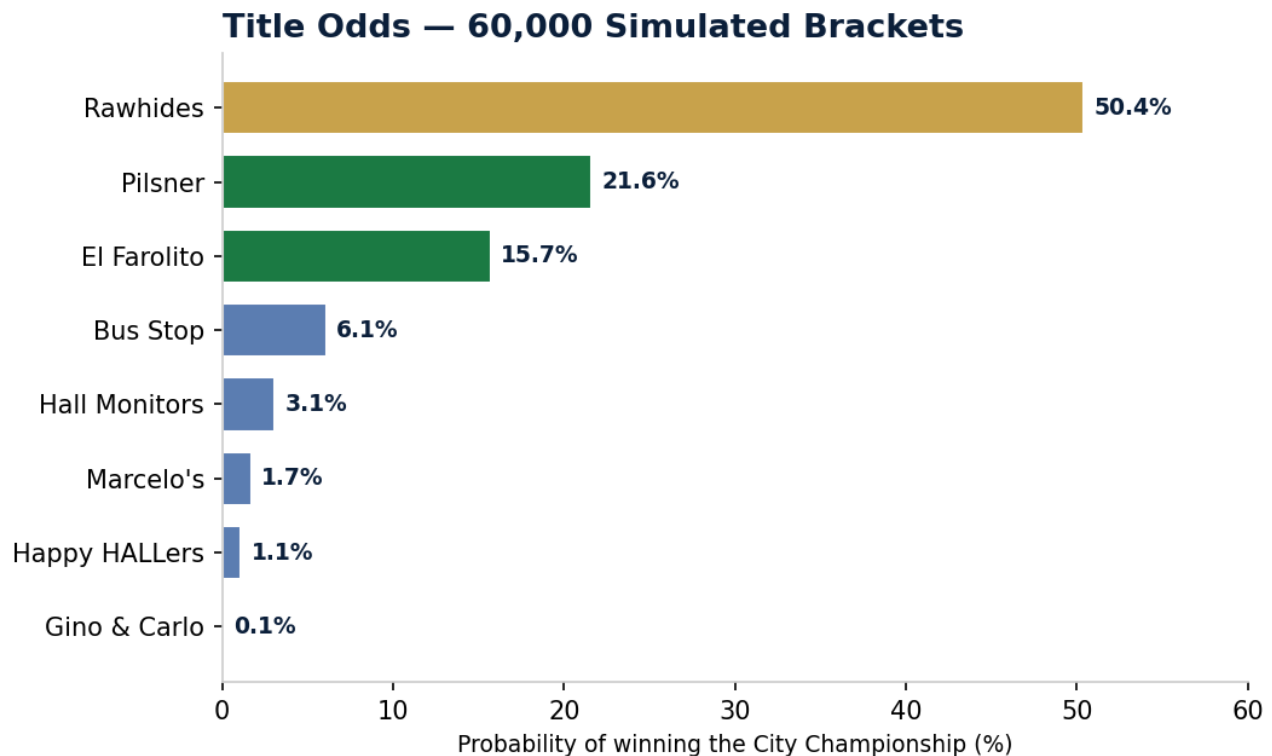
SFPA Spring 2026 City Championship

The Betting Line — A Visual Handicapper's Report

Power ratings · win-probability model · Monte-Carlo title equity · the board

Prepared June 24, 2026 · post-Week 14 (final regular season) · race-to-9 model backtested at 73% on 212 in-season matches (Brier 0.19)

Happy Lounge Rawhides are the clear favorite — champions in **50%** of 60,000 simulated brackets (fair odds ~-102). After a dominant Week-14 win that finalized the seeds, they pulled clear of the field. **Pilsner InnDecisives** (+363, 22%) is the principal threat, with **El Farolito Shooters** (+537, 16%) a live third. Together the top three hold ~88% of all title equity; everyone else is a longshot.



Gold = favorite · green = live contenders · steel = the field. The three-team cluster at the top is the whole story; below Pilsner, equity falls off a cliff.

How These Numbers Were Built

1. A power rating for every team, earned on the table. Each team starts the season rated by the Fargo (skill) ratings of its top four players, then that rating moves up or down after every one of the season's 14 weeks based on actual game-by-game results — win big and you climb, scuffle and you slide. This is a standard Elo system, the same math used to rank chess players and sports teams.

2. Turning ratings into win probabilities — and proving they work. Playoff matches are a **race to 9**: the two teams play individual games until one side reaches 9 wins, and the match stops there (so a 9-3 match is over after 12 games — the score need not add to 16). The rating gap sets each team's per-game win chance, capped so no single game is treated as more lopsided than 85/15 (pool has too much variance for locks), and we play the race out game by game. If a match reaches **8-8, a single deciding game is played** — each team sends its highest-Fargo player, and that one game is settled by those two players' head-to-head Fargo expectancy. We back-tested the per-game engine against this season's results: run week by week across all 14 weeks, it correctly called **73% of 212 matches** (Brier score 0.187 — well better than a coin flip), and its confidence levels are well-calibrated (see the appendix). That hit-rate is the basis for trusting the odds.

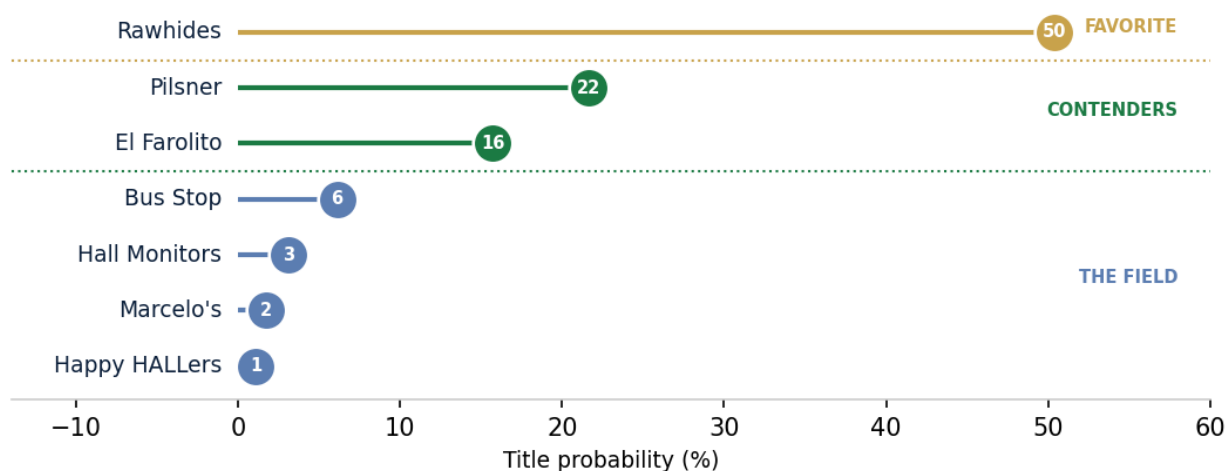
3. Simulating the actual tournament 60,000 times. Title odds aren't a guess — we play out the full 16-team double-elimination bracket (winners' side, losers'/B-side, and the grand final where the B-side team must win twice), every match a game-by-game race to 9 with the 8-8 tiebreaker, 60,000 times and count how often each team wins. Every number in this report — title odds, survival percentages, the bracket — comes from this one simulation, so they're mutually consistent.

4. Did prior seasons matter? We measured it, instead of guessing. Rawhides and Pilsner have met in the City Championship final four straight seasons (Rawhides won all four) — a pattern a single-season model can't see, which argues for a "pedigree" weight. But rather than set that weight by feel, we tested it: across the last three championships, we checked whether each team won *more playoff matches than its regular-season rating predicted*. The result was decisive and asymmetric. **Pilsner overperformed dramatically** — winning 12 of 18 playoff matches when their seeding predicted about 7 (a statistically significant effect) — so their pedigree weight is kept (a conservative +45 Elo). **Rawhides did not.** Their playoff record is statistically indistinguishable from "a top seed doing exactly what a top seed should" (the effect comfortably includes zero), so we removed the Rawhides bump entirely. Winning four finals as the highest-rated team isn't extra evidence — it's the rating already working.

Why this matters for the headline: even without a pedigree bump, Rawhides still hold the league's top power rating on this season's play — so they grade out as the narrow favorite on merit, not on borrowed history. But the gap to El Farolito and Pilsner is small: this is a genuine three-team race, not a coronation. Every adjustment in the report now has a number behind it, not a feel. Pool is high-variance, so treat these as probabilities, not predictions — even the favorite loses far more often than it wins.

The Board

Three Tiers: Favorite, Contenders, and the Field



Team	Seed	Title %	Fair Dec	Moneyline	Posted (vig)
Happy Lounge Rawhides	1	50.4%	1.98	-102	1.68
Pilsner InnDecisives	7	21.6%	4.63	+363	3.92
El Farolito Shooters	2	15.7%	6.37	+537	5.40
Bus Stop Flyers	3	6.1%	16.39	+1539	13.89
Hall Monitors	4	3.1%	32.26	+3126	27.34
Marcelo's Hall Stars	8	1.7%	58.82	+5782	49.85
Happy HALLers	5	1.1%	90.91	+8991	77.04
Gino & Carlo	9	0.1%	1000.00	+99900	847.46
Pocket Full of Fizz	6	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	10	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Friends Crooked Cues	11	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Route 101 Dalmatians	12	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	13	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Temple Holy Smokes	14	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Bus Slop	15	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Lower Haight Misfits	16	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73

"Posted" odds include a standard ~18% book margin. The gold line marks the chalk cut: above it, true contenders; below, longshots.

The Favorite and the Field

After Week 14, the top of the board has separated — **Happy Lounge Rawhides 50%, Pilsner InnDecisives 22%, El Farolito Shooters 16%**. Last week this read as a near-even three-team race; the final regular-season results, folded into the power ratings, have pushed Rawhides clear and reshuffled the chase. Here is what moved.

1. Rawhides' Week-14 statement. Rawhides closed the regular season by beating El Farolito head-to-head 11-5 — a result that both raised their own power rating (now 1689 Elo, the league's best) and pulled El Farolito's down. That single swing is most of why Rawhides jumped from a low-30s favorite to a coin-flip-or-better at 50%. The model still caps any one match at 90/10 (pool is high-variance), so they are far from a lock — but they are now clearly the team to beat.

2. Pilsner inherit second. Pilsner (1672 Elo including their earned +45 pedigree bump) are now the second-strongest team on the board and the most likely challenger at 22%. Their B-side pedigree — verified in the data on page 2 — means a single early loss doesn't end them, which is exactly why a 7-seed can sit second in title equity.

3. El Farolito slip to third. El Farolito (1661 Elo) remain a genuine contender at 16%, but the Week-14 loss to Rawhides cost them both rating and the head-to-head tiebreak that had been flattering their seed. They drew into the same B-side gauntlet and now profile as the third wheel of the top tier rather than a co-favorite.

Bottom line: this is no longer the dead-even three-way race of last week. Rawhides are a clear favorite on current form, Pilsner are the chief threat, and El Farolito are live but a step back. Below those three, equity falls off a cliff.

Bracket Equity — How Far Each Team Survives

How often each team is still alive at each stage of the bracket. Because this is double-elimination, "survival" counts a team that's alive on either side — the winners' bracket or the losers' (B-side) — so a strong team that stumbles once isn't necessarily gone. The favorites don't just win more finals; they stay alive deep into the bracket far more reliably, which is what compounds into title equity.

Bracket Equity — Probability of Reaching Each Round (%)				
1. Rawhides	99	82	73	50.4
7. Pilsner	93	52	45	21.6
2. El Farolito	98	48	37	15.7
3. Bus Stop	88	73	20	6.1
4. Hall Monitors	89	56	12	3.1
8. Marcelo's	67	14	7	1.7
5. Happy HALLers	79	38	5	1.1
9. Gino & Carlo	33	4	1	0.1
6. Pocket Fizz	57	14	0	0.0
10. LH Glue Factory	7	1	0	0.0
11. Friends Cues	43	9	0	0.0
12. Route 101	21	4	0	0.0
13. Karl's Beacon	11	2	0	0.0
14. Temple Smokes	12	5	0	0.0
15. Bus Slop	2	0	0	0.0
16. Lower Haight	1	0	0	0.0
	Reach QF	Reach Semis	Reach Final	Win Title

Every column here comes from the same 60,000-run double-elimination simulation, so they're mutually consistent and the bold **Win Title** column matches the odds board exactly. Note that Pilsner's deep-run odds track its title odds — the B-side safety net is exactly why a mid-seed can be the 2nd-most-likely champion. Teams like Hall Monitors and Bus Stop stay alive a while but rarely reach the Grand Final — they run into the top three.

Power Ratings — The Engine Behind Every Number

This is the heart of the model: each team's Elo rating after all 14 weeks. Only **Pilsner** carries a pedigree bump (+45), the one team whose playoff overperformance we could verify in the data. **Read the first two columns together** — a team's *strength* (Elo rank) often differs from its *seed* (regular-season standing), and that gap is exactly what produces the bracket's projected upsets.

Elo Rank	Seed	Team	Elo Rating	Top-4 Fargo	Note
1	#1	Happy Lounge Rawhides	1689	611	
2	#7	Pilsner InnDecisives	1672	539	+45 pedigree
3	#2	El Farolito Shooters	1661	547	
4	#3	Bus Stop Flyers	1631	551	
5	#8	Marcelo's Hall Stars	1618	554	under-seeded (stronger than seed)
6	#4	Hall Monitors	1617	567	over-seeded (weaker than seed)
7	#5	Happy HALLers	1603	504	over-seeded (weaker than seed)
8	#9	Gino & Carlo	1579	505	
9	#6	Pocket Full of Fizz	1552	515	over-seeded (weaker than seed)
10	#10	Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	1542	451	
11	#11	Friends Crooked Cues	1539	478	
12	#12	Route 101 Dalmatians	1533	455	
13	#14	Temple Holy Smokes	1528	514	
14	#13	Karl's Freakin' Beacon	1508	430	
15	#16	Lower Haight Misfits	1486	410	
16	#15	Bus Slop	1470	443	

Key disconnects: **Pilsner InnDecisives** grades out as the #2 team by Elo but is seeded only #7. **Marcelo's Hall Stars** are likewise stronger than their seeds. That is why, in the bracket, you'll see a lower seed knock out a higher one — the seeds come from regular-season records, but the projected results come from these ratings.

The Projected Bracket

Seeds are set by regular-season standing (final, after the Week 14 results below). The City Championship is a 16-team **double-elimination** event: lose on the A-side (winners' bracket, Tue/Wed) and you drop to the B-side (losers' bracket, Thursdays) where one more loss ends your run. The B-side survivor earns a Grand Final rematch but must beat the A-side finalist twice.

Spring 2026 City Championship — Full Projected Double-Elimination Bracket

WINNERS BRACKET (A-side · Tue/Wed · lose once → drop to B-side)



LOSERS BRACKET (B-side · Thursdays · one more loss = eliminated)



The model's most-likely path, drawn in full. **A-side:** chalk largely holds and Rawhides emerge from the winners' bracket to reach the Grand Final from the A-side (the short path). **B-side (Thursdays):** each A-side loser drops into the losers' bracket and must win out or go home — the diagram shows every projected matchup and elimination, with Pilsner battling through to win the B-side final. Pilsner then earn a Grand Final rematch with Rawhides, but as the B-side team they would have to beat Rawhides *twice*; the model has Rawhides closing it out for the title — the recurring Rawhides–Pilsner final, true to recent history.

How to read this bracket against the odds board. This diagram is the *single most-likely path* — one tournament. The title odds come from 60,000 *different* simulated tournaments. They answer different questions, so they don't have to rank teams the same way. Here they largely agree at the top: Rawhides win it and Pilsner reach the Grand Final from the B-side. But the exact finishing order is a coincidence of this particular draw, not a rule — in plenty of the other 60,000 simulations it flips. "Most-likely champion" and "most-likely single bracket" are not the same calculation: trust the odds board for who's most likely to win, and read the bracket as one vivid example of how a single tournament could actually unfold.

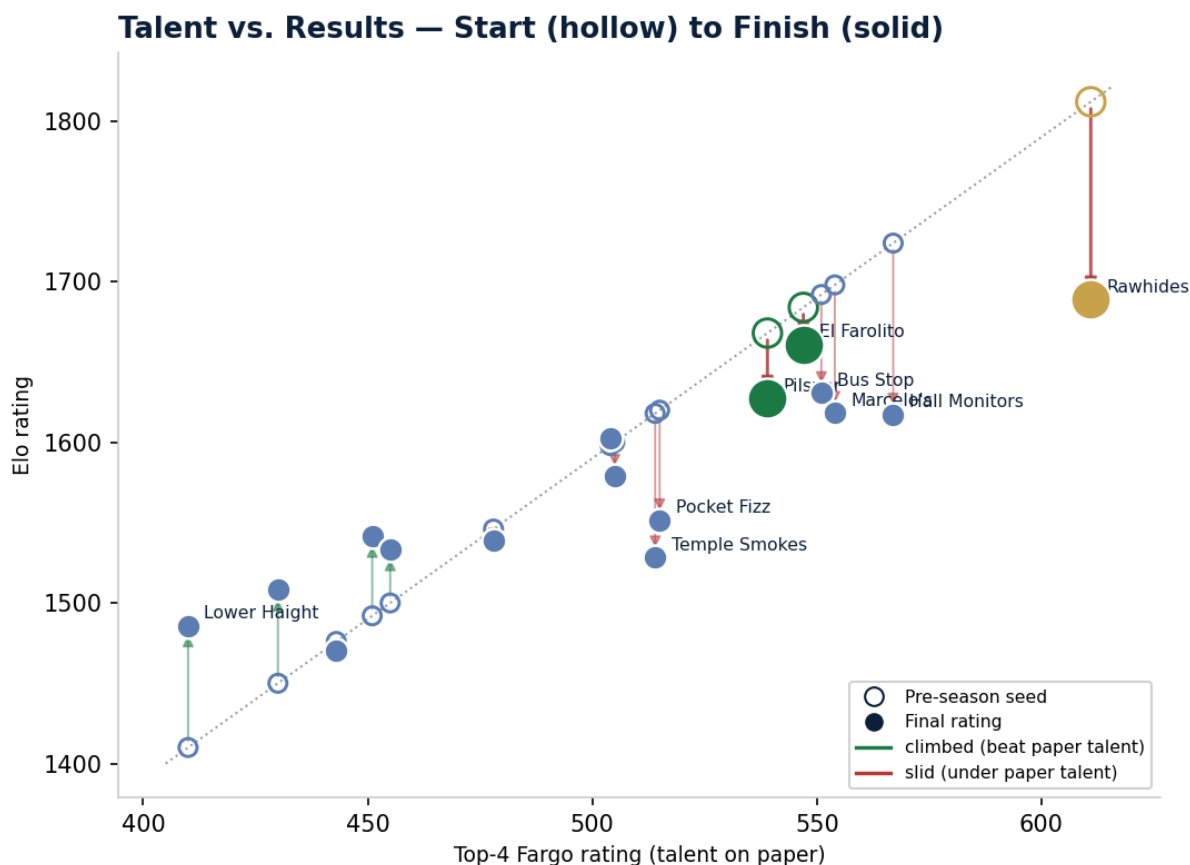
Week 14 Results (set the final seeds)

Matchup (top region)	Final Score	Winner
Happy Lounge Rawhides vs El Farolito Shooters	11-5	Happy Lounge Rawhides
Hall Monitors vs Bus Stop Flyers	6-10	Bus Stop Flyers
Happy HALLers vs Pocket Full of Fizz	8-8	Tie (1 pt each)
Pilsner InnDecisives vs Marcelo's Hall Stars	9-7	Pilsner InnDecisives
Gino & Carlo vs Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	10-6	Gino & Carlo
Route 101 Dalmatians vs Friends Crooked Cues	7-9	Friends Crooked Cues
Karl's Freakin' Beacon vs Temple Holy Smokes	8-8	Tie (1 pt each)
Lower Haight Misfits vs Billiard Palacade Sharks	8-8	Tie (1 pt each)

Week 14 is regular season, where a match can finish 8-8 — a genuine tie worth a point each (no tiebreaker game; that only happens in the playoffs). These are the actual final-week results; they set the seeds, and this year Week 14 shifted the cutline — Bus Stop's 12-4 win lifted them into the 16-team field, bumping Billiard Palacade Sharks out.

Talent vs. Results

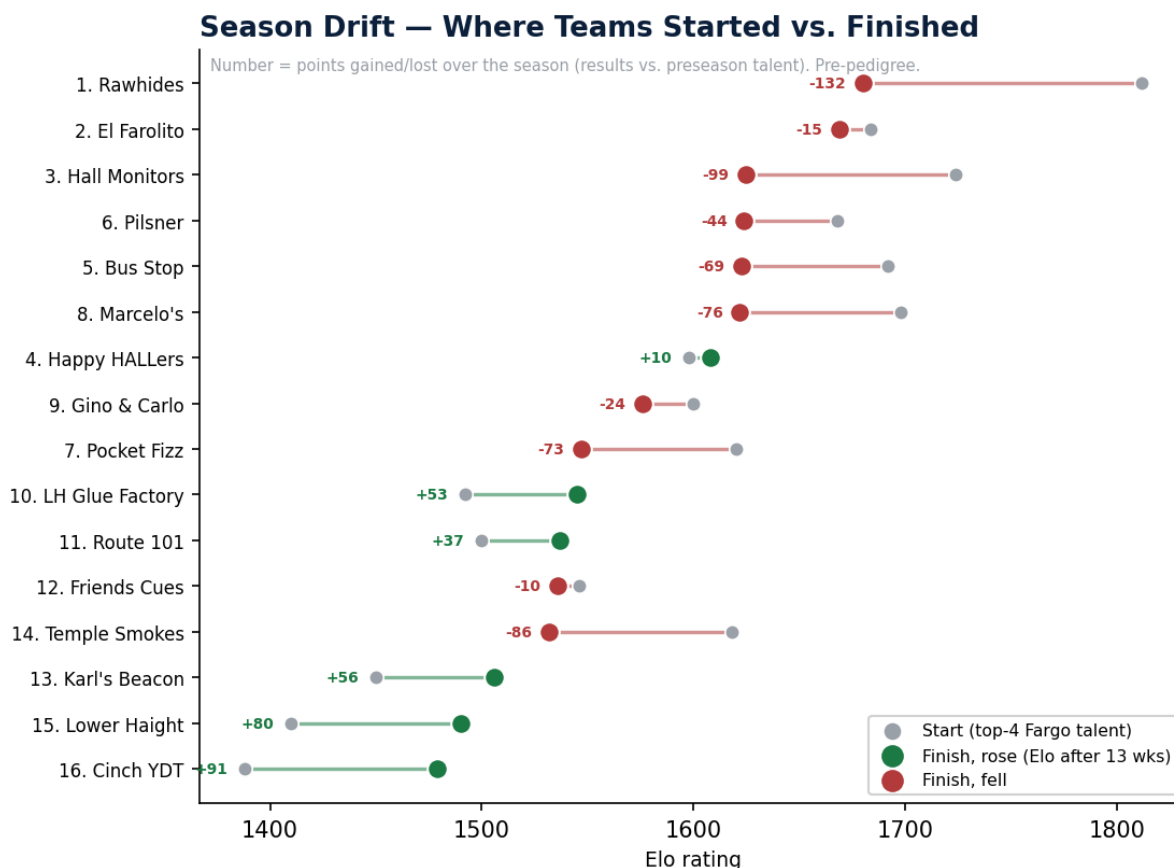
Every team's paper talent (top-4 Fargo) against how it actually performed (Elo from 14 weeks). Teams above the dashed line are beating their ratings; teams below are underperforming. This is where the contenders separate from the pretenders.



El Farolito and Pilsner sit well above the line — they win more than their rosters suggest, the mark of a real playoff team. The high-Fargo names that sit on or below the line (Hall Monitors, Marcelo's) are the classic "better on paper than in practice" trap.

Season Drift — How the Season Moved Each Team

The same idea as the scatter, made concrete. Every team is *seeded* a starting Elo from its preseason talent (top-4 Fargo); 14 weeks of results then push that rating up or down. The gap — the "drift" — is the cleanest single measure of who over- or under-played their roster this season. (This is pure on-table performance, before any playoff pedigree adjustment.)



Team	Seed	Start Elo (talent)	Final Elo (results)	Drift
Happy Lounge Rawhides	#1	1812	1689	-123
El Farolito Shooters	#2	1684	1661	-23
Bus Stop Flyers	#3	1692	1631	-61
Pilsner InnDecisives	#7	1668	1627	-41
Marcelo's Hall Stars	#8	1698	1618	-80
Hall Monitors	#4	1724	1617	-107
Happy HALLers	#5	1598	1603	+5
Gino & Carlo	#9	1600	1579	-21
Pocket Full of Fizz	#6	1620	1552	-68
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	#10	1492	1542	+50
Friends Crooked Cues	#11	1546	1539	-7
Route 101 Dalmatians	#12	1500	1533	+33
Temple Holy Smokes	#14	1618	1528	-90
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	#13	1450	1508	+58

Team	Seed	Start Elo (talent)	Final Elo (results)	Drift
Lower Haight Misfits	#16	1410	1486	+76
Bus Slop	#15	1476	1470	-6

Reading it: **Rawhides started so far ahead on talent (1812) that even a -123 drift leaves them the league's top final Elo rating (1689)** — the strongest team by results even after that slide, which is why they're the title favorite despite carrying no pedigree bump. The risers (Lower Haight Misfits +76, Karl's Freakin' Beacon +58, Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory +50) are lower seeds who played above their ratings; the steep fallers (Happy Lounge Rawhides -123, Hall Monitors -107, Temple Holy Smokes -90) are high-Fargo teams that underdelivered — a warning sign the bracket respects.

The Dynasty Context

The league's defining pattern is real: the same two teams (Rawhides and Pilsner) have met in the City Championship final four years running, Rawhides winning every time. But we tested what that history is actually worth (see page 2) — and only **Pilsner** demonstrably outperforms its rating in the playoffs. Rawhides win as the favorite they already are. So the dynasty informs the line through Pilsner's earned bump, not by anointing Rawhides.

Four Straight Finals: The Rawhides-Pilsner Dynasty

	Spring 2024	Fall 2024	Spring 2025	Fall 2025	Spring 2026
Champion	Rawhides	Rawhides	Rawhides	Rawhides	?
Runner-up	Pilsner	Pilsner	Pilsner	Pilsner	

The Verdict

Clear favorite: Happy Lounge Rawhides (-102, ~50%). On this season's actual results they grade out as the league's strongest team by a comfortable margin — the top power rating, earned on the table, with no borrowed history, and a Week-14 head-to-head win over their nearest challenger to finish. Favored, though pool variance keeps even a 50% favorite losing half the time.

Chief threat: Pilsner InnDecisives (+363, 22%). The second-strongest team on the board, and their verified B-side pedigree (page 2) means one early loss doesn't end them — the reason a low seed sits second in title equity. The most likely team to deny Rawhides.

Live but a step back: El Farolito Shooters (+537, 16%). Still a real contender, but the Week-14 loss cost them rating and the head-to-head, dropping them to third. Dangerous in the B-side bracket. Below these three, equity falls off a cliff.

Model: Elo power ratings seeded on Fargo and updated over 14 weeks of game-level results; log5/Elo matchup probabilities with a 90/10 variance cap; a data-derived pedigree bump for Pilsner only (the one team that measurably overperforms in the playoffs); 60,000-run double-elimination Monte Carlo. Backtested at 73% match accuracy (Brier 0.19). Pool is high-variance — these are probabilities, not predictions. For entertainment and analysis.

What Changed This Week

This is the first snapshot built on the **final regular-season results**. Last week's edition used *projected* Week-14 scores to set the seeds; this one uses the actual Week-14 results (played overnight June 23), folded into both the seeding and the power ratings. The headline moved a lot.

The Headline: a New Favorite

Happy Lounge Rawhides overtook El Farolito Shooters for the top of the board. Last week El Farolito Shooters led at 34%; this week Happy Lounge Rawhides are clear at 50%. The cause is concrete and on the table: in the final week the two title favorites met head-to-head and **Rawhides beat El Farolito 11-5**. That single result raised Rawhides' power rating, lowered El Farolito's, and handed Rawhides the head-to-head — a roughly 19-point swing in title equity from one match.

Bracket Field Change (an upset at the cutline)

In: Bus Slop. Out: Cinch You're Down There. The Teams-page standings only ran through Week 13; once Week 14 was added, Bus Slop's 12-4 win vaulted them past the cut while Cinch You're Down There's tie left them just short. Cinch You're Down There had appeared in last week's projected bracket; they miss the real one. This is the only change to the 16-team field.

Title-Odds Movers

Team	Last Week	This Week	Change
Happy Lounge Rawhides	31.8%	50.4%	+18.6 pts
El Farolito Shooters	34.3%	15.7%	-18.6 pts
Bus Stop Flyers	3.6%	6.1%	+2.5 pts
Happy HALLers	2.3%	1.1%	-1.2 pts
Hall Monitors	3.9%	3.1%	-0.8 pts
Marcelo's Hall Stars	2.2%	1.7%	-0.5 pts

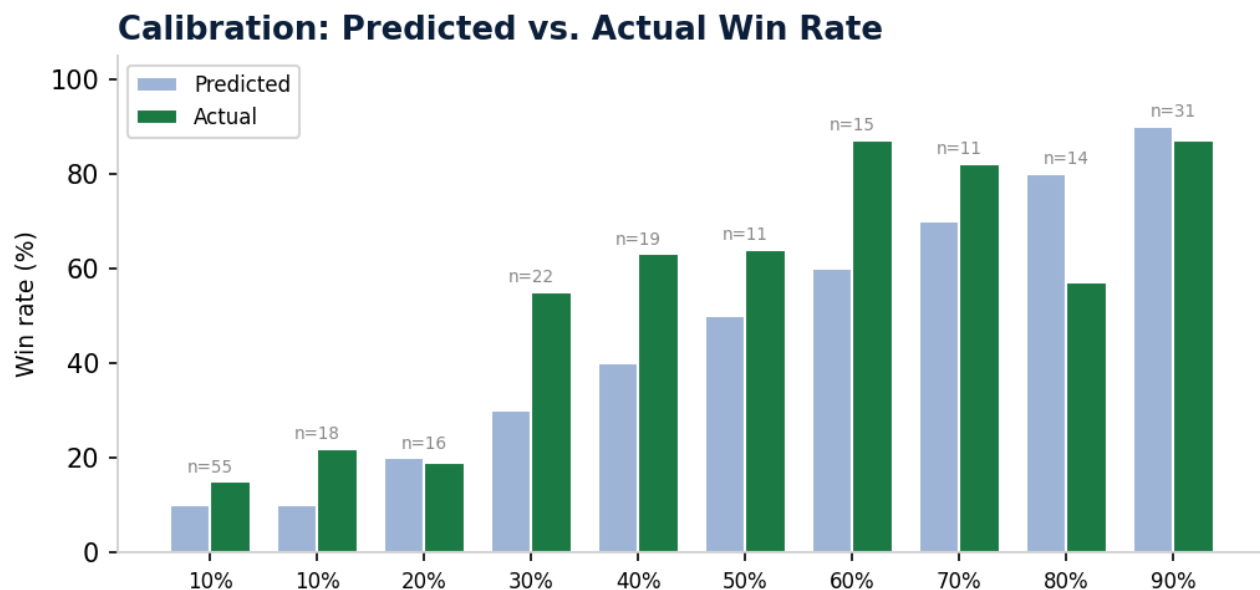
Any team not listed moved less than half a point. The two big moves are mirror images — the Rawhides–El Farolito head-to-head transferred equity directly from one to the other. Bus Stop ticked up on a strong finish; the rest of the field barely twitched.

Upset Watch

Regular season: no top-seed shocker — chalk mostly held in Week 14, but Bus Slop's 12-4 result was the consequential one, swinging the final playoff berth. **Playoffs:** none yet — the City Championship bracket hasn't begun. Once it does, this section will track A-side losses that drop contenders to the B-side and any lower-seed wins over higher seeds.

Appendix — Model Calibration

Proof the odds can be trusted: matches the model calls at a given confidence win at about that rate. Predicted vs. actual track closely across all confidence bands.



Overall 73% of 212 matches called correctly; Brier 0.187 (0.25 = coin flip).